The Mapping Window

What happens when public records stop being expensive to read

WORKING NOTE · ANDREW MORTON · PALMER LAKE, COLORADO

The short version

Almost everything about who owns what, and how they got it, has been public for two hundred years. It was never hidden. It was expensive to assemble — so expensive that only people with a litigation budget, a family office, or an academic career ever put the pieces together.

That cost just fell to nearly nothing.

Two things follow, and they arrive together. Ordinary people are about to have private-investigator capability on each other, which will cause real damage in ordinary places for reasons that have nothing to do with justice. And structures that families, corporations, and governments spent generations making too complicated to follow are about to become legible to anyone willing to look.

Both are happening. Neither cancels the other.

What a record actually is

Strip the vocabulary away and a property record is four things: a name, a date, a thing, and a transfer. Someone gave something to someone else on a certain day, and a clerk wrote it down.

That's the whole machine. A deed says this person sold this parcel to that person on this date. A will says these holdings went to these heirs. A corporate filing says this entity is owned by that one. A probate file lists everything the deceased owned and where it went.

These exist because the system requires them. If you can't prove you own something, you can't sell it, borrow against it, insure it, or defend it. The record exists because owners need it to exist.

And it's public on purpose. The legal principle is called constructive notice: records are open specifically so that the world is presumed to have read them. That presumption is the reason recording works at all — it's what makes your deed beat someone else's later claim. Nobody writing those statutes imagined the presumption becoming literally true.

That's the crack in the whole thing. The paper trail was built by and for the people it now exposes, and its openness was their idea.

It was never secret. It was expensive.

The SS Central America sank in 1857 carrying Gold Rush cargo. When it was located and salvaged in 1988, insurance companies appeared with documentation of claims they had paid out 131 years earlier, asserting ownership of the recovered gold. The court took the paperwork seriously. The finders kept most of it, but a stack of 1857 receipts was recognized as a live interest in metal pulled off the seafloor a century and a third later.

Those documents didn’t come from nowhere. Insurers keep continuous archives as ordinary business. The records just sat unexamined until something surfaced that made the assembly worth paying for.

That’s the whole pattern. In the United States every piece of land traces back to an original government patent or colonial grant — which is why a title search ends instead of running forever. Documented start, documented present, finite transfers between. Not mysterious. Just long, tedious, and scattered across county courthouses, state archives, registries, and probate files never designed to be read together.

The tedium was the defense. A researcher could spend a career on one branch of one corporate structure. A firm could reconstruct a chain when the client had enough at stake to fund hundreds of billable hours. Title companies built private indexes of county records — better organized than the counties’ own — and licensed access. None of it secret. Public information behind a price.

The comparison is protein folding. The rules were never hidden; they were published physics. But the combinations were so numerous that predicting one structure could take a lab years. Then pattern-matching systems ate the problem and a career’s work became an afternoon’s.

Ownership structures are the same shape: many pieces, all public, exhausting to combine. Exactly what these systems do well.

The gradient

The clearest evidence of who the recording system was built for sits inside a single transaction.

When a person was sold in 1840, both sides got written down. Look at what survived of each.

The person sold: often a first name. An age. A dollar figure. One line in an estate inventory, in a county where the courthouse may have burned. Frequently the entire surviving record of a human being.

The person buying: an unbroken chain. Deed, will, probate, next deed, incorporation, trust — running forward two hundred years without a gap, because keeping that line continuous is the entire purpose of property law.

Same transaction. Same day. Sometimes the same page. One side recorded as an asset description, the other as a title that had to survive.

That gradient isn’t an accident of preservation. It’s a readout of who the system served. And it means the buyer’s half is fully intact right now, waiting.

Two layers, one of them already unblocked

The material splits into two piles with different constraints, and they’ll get worked in the wrong order relative to how much anyone thinks they matter.

The modern layer is already digital and already free. SEC filings with full-text search and an API. All fifty state business registries. Federal court dockets. Nonprofit tax returns as machine-readable data. Campaign contributions. Lobbying disclosures. Bill text and sponsorship. Federal contracts and grants. UCC filings. Oil and gas permits, operator transfers, and bonding records. County assessor and recorder databases in most populous counties, generally back to somewhere between 1970 and 1990.

Nothing in that list waits on anything. Every modern chain closes with records that are downloadable today.

The historical layer is the one behind glass. Pre-1970 deeds, probate files, estate inventories — physically present in courthouse basements, legally public, functionally invisible. The digitization cutoff is arbitrary county by county, and it lands right where the deep chains live.

So the accountability work is unblocked and the restitution work is gated on scanning. That’s most of why the modern version gets built first, regardless of which anyone considers more urgent.

The case that proves it: abandoned wells

Millions of unplugged oil and gas wells sit across the country leaking methane and brine, and the public is paying to close them — billions of federal dollars appropriated for exactly that. The standard explanation is that responsible parties can’t be found.

They can. The chain is fully recorded, one transfer at a time.

A major drills the profitable decades, then sells the declining field to a smaller operator, who sells to a smaller one, who sells to a two-man LLC carrying a blanket bond worth less than the cost of plugging three wells. That operator goes bankrupt. The obligation dies with the entity. Every transfer in that sequence was filed with a state regulator, because operator transfers legally must be. Permits, bonds, production reports, bankruptcy dockets — sitting in the agency’s own system.

And the tracing method is proven, because the government already runs it elsewhere. Superfund’s “potentially responsible party” searches are chain-of-title archaeology through decades of corporate reshuffling, and they recover real money from successor companies. The reason nobody runs it on wells is arithmetic: a search costs more than plugging one well, and there are millions of wells. The per-site tracing cost exceeded the per-site liability, so taxpayers pay instead.

Not a doctrine problem. Not a records problem. A unit-economics problem — and the unit economics just changed.

The legal hooks are already there: successor liability where a buyer is a mere continuation of the seller, statutes in several producing states keeping prior operators on the hook, fraudulent transfer law when assets moved out ahead of known obligations. And unlike everything historical, this one has an obvious customer. Agencies currently spending appropriated money would rather bill someone. They have standing, subpoena power, and budget motive. What they lack is cheap tracing.

The value trail holds — and bankruptcy is losing

The recurring claim is that the money vanished into dissolved companies and nobody can say where it went. The record disagrees.

In the early 2000s, California, Illinois, and several cities required companies doing business with them to disclose slavery-era records. That produced named institutions: Aetna disclosed writing life insurance on enslaved people; JPMorgan Chase disclosed that predecessor Louisiana banks accepted enslaved people as loan collateral and took ownership on default; Wachovia and New York Life made comparable disclosures. Those companies exist today only through 180 years of mergers. The trail held across every one of them — and it was produced by a disclosure requirement, not a lawsuit.

The dissolution dodge is also weaker than assumed. Successor liability is real doctrine; asbestos litigation chased successors through decades of restructuring and largely won. And in 2024 the Supreme Court struck down Purdue Pharma’s bankruptcy plan specifically because it released the Sackler family from liability without claimants’ consent, after the family had pulled billions out ahead of the filing. That maneuver — extract value, then let the shell fail — was tested at the highest level and rejected within the last two years.

But the courtroom is mostly closed, and not on the merits. The consolidated slavery reparations litigation was dismissed on standing and statute of limitations. Appeals don’t fix that. New evidence doesn’t fix that. What fixes it is a legislature passing a revival window — exactly what dozens of states did for time-barred child sexual abuse claims over the last decade, reopening conduct from the 1960s and 70s.

Which relocates the whole thing. The evidence goes to legislatures, not courts, because procedure closed the courthouse and only a legislature can reopen it. The map’s function isn’t to win a case. It’s to make a revival statute politically expensive to refuse.

What gets built

Not one app. Domain by domain, a few professionals each, maintained rather than published once.

That’s already underway: company registries, sanctions and ownership data, power-network maps, money in politics, fossil infrastructure tracked asset by asset, historical enslavement records, offshore leak databases. Each one a small group who got tired of rebuilding the same dataset.

The bottleneck isn’t more databases. It’s entity resolution between them. Is the “R. Whitmore” on a Delaware filing the same person as the “Robert Whitmore Jr.” on a Texas permit and the “Whitmore

Family Trust” on a deed? That question is why these sets have sat adjacent without merging — and it’s precisely the part that got cheap. Shared data standards and cross-referencing platforms already exist and are used by investigative journalists now.

The legislative piece has a completed proof too. In 2019, reporters ran text-matching across state bills and found thousands copied nearly verbatim from model templates written by lobbying groups — the same language surfacing in statehouse after statehouse. Crude tooling, and it worked. The bill text and sponsorship data are public and machine-readable.

The town layer

The unit that matters most is smaller than any of that.

Mapping Prejudice at the University of Minnesota is the completed local proof: volunteers transcribed county deed records to find racially restrictive covenants, built the canonical dataset, and mapped every one. No litigation. The state subsequently passed a law letting homeowners discharge covenants from their titles, and other counties copied the model.

Town scale works for a reason beyond cost: the entity count is small enough that a person can verify a match by knowing the place. National entity resolution is hard. “Is that the same Bill Hargrove” is answerable by someone who lives there.

What the maintenance layer produces is the actual finding. A snapshot shows three unrelated LLCs. A time series shows one man — officer of the operator that went bankrupt in 2009, organizer of the one that folded in 2016, registered agent for the one holding the permits now. Same PO box, same attorney, same phone across three separate filings. Invisible to a single pull, obvious across fifteen years. People rebuild the entity; they rarely rebuild the whole administrative footprint, because it’s a hassle and nobody was watching.

That is almost exactly the function of the local reporter who kept a beat for twenty years and remembered who was behind the last three things. That role disappeared with local papers and nothing replaced the memory part.

And the records that hide are local. Public records law sets a floor, not a ceiling — it says what must be produced on request, not what may be posted. Almost everything in that gap is discretionary: check registers showing actual vendor payments rather than the adopted budget; assessment appeals showing who got their valuation cut; tax abatement and TIF agreements; contract change orders; variance and code enforcement files; officials’ calendars and email. All disclosable. Almost never posted.

Two things make withholding easy — stretched executive-session exemptions, since challenging one means suing; and format as soft denial, where handing over a scanned image of a database is technically compliance and functionally refusal.

Some counties also sell bulk access as a revenue line, or signed exclusive contracts handing digitization and hosting to a private vendor with a revenue share. Fee-funded offices have no discretion about charging. Signing away bulk access is a choice, made by a named official at a public meeting with a recorded vote. Those contracts are themselves public records — term, renewal date, revenue split — which turns a philosophical argument into a line item with an expiration date.

That instinct has also been tested and it loses. The Supreme Court held in 2020 that Georgia couldn't copyright the annotated version of its own state code. The federal courts' per-page docket system was sued over overcharging and settled. The pattern is consistent: public-records paywalls tend not to survive being challenged.

What this does to ordinary people

The revolver in the 1800s West wasn't new violence. It was an equalizer — it removed the training and physical advantage lethal capability used to require.

What followed wasn't one war. It was decades of small, scattered fights, because the tool arrived faster than any shared sense of when using it was legitimate. Most of what people picture as the Wild West is that gap.

The same gap is opening, and it lands locally first — not on institutions, but on a neighbor who wants to know where a coworker's money came from, on a divorce, on a school board grudge. People will build the dossier that used to require hiring a professional, about each other, and no norm exists yet for when that's accountability and when it's harassment.

That norm arrives the way it always does: formal law, social consequence, and enough bad outcomes that rules harden around them afterward. In the meantime real damage happens to real people over nothing that matters.

How this goes wrong

Three failure modes. Not warnings — the mechanism of the damage.

True facts, false story. Every link checks out and the conclusion is still wrong. This entity owns this parcel: verifiable. This person sits on that board: verifiable. Therefore they did the thing: not verifiable, and not made true by the accuracy underneath it. Better sourcing makes this stronger, not weaker — nobody has to defend a lie, only a leap, and the leap is the part nobody examines.

Guilt by adjacency. Once consequences follow from public association rather than any process examining individual conduct, the mechanism can't distinguish someone who meaningfully benefited from someone who merely appears in the same filing. It never has, at any scale it's been run. Speed is what prevents the distinction.

Structural ubiquity. Some names top every list by construction. Diversified institutional holders own everything. A handful of law firms, registered agents, and trustee banks appear in millions of filings as a service function. When a thousand mapping efforts converge on the same names, part of that is signal and part is just who is structurally everywhere — and the aggregate version of the first failure is exactly this: the map is right, the frequency is right, the inference from frequency is wrong.

And the record indexes legalism, not wrongdoing. Value taken by force, by handshake, by custom, or by moving onto land and staying left no chain and stays unrecoverable. The meticulous get caught; the crude get missed. Frequency partly measures fastidiousness.

What separates what survives

This is a prediction, not advice.

The projects that hold up will publish provenance to the document — book, page, image — so any claim can be walked back by a hostile reader. They'll timestamp every assertion and show an as-of date, because on a power map a stale record isn't a gap, it's a live falsehood attached to a name. They'll state their confidence thresholds for entity matching, which is the one genuinely non-computational judgment left in the pipeline. And they'll document the null model — what ubiquity looks like when nobody is coordinating anything.

The ones that don't will get a single finding discredited and take everything else down with it.

The character judgment is where this most often breaks, and the distinction is between conduct and descent. That an ancestor's fortune came from selling people is a documented fact and reading it isn't a leap. That a descendant is therefore culpable runs on bloodline. But spending money now to defeat an obligation the public is currently paying instead is conduct — an act, taken by a living person, and it leaves the best-indexed trail in the country, because litigation is dockets.

The durable form of the historical claim isn't a character judgment at all. It's *benefited from* — a documented fact requiring nothing about anyone's virtue. An heir can be blameless and still hold value that traces to a wrong. That framing has no counter, because there's nothing to defend except the chain, and the chain is the part that exists.

The fog is recent, and it's being poured now

The opacity around modern wealth isn't ancient. It's new, and it's still being added.

Probate is public — that's the step where holdings become a matter of record, and it's why the chain stayed visible for two centuries. Trusts skip probate, and that isn't a hidden feature, it's the selling point.

Then it became permanent. Beginning in the mid-1980s, several states repealed the old common-law rule forcing trusts to eventually end and distribute. Perpetual trusts became a product those states now market against each other.

And the disclosure meant to counter it keeps getting hollowed out. The federal beneficial ownership registry was built, then in March 2025 the requirement for U.S. companies and persons to report was removed. New York's version took effect in January 2026, and the information it collects goes into a database that isn't public.

A transparency law whose output isn't public. Not a metaphor — the current state.

No intent needs proving. The sequence is on the record and the beneficiaries are identifiable.

The one-way door

Restrictions run forward. That's the whole thing.

New trust structures, sealed registries, narrowed disclosure — all of it stops the next stretch of chain from being written. None of it retracts what's recorded. Once something is copied out of a courthouse, walling off the courthouse doesn't pull it back. Copying costs nothing. Deletion isn't possible in any meaningful sense.

Which puts the people alive right now at the last fully documented point of a chain running unbroken back to the original grant — at the exact moment reading it became cheap, and just as the recording of it is being shut off going forward.

Whatever gets assembled in this window stays assembled.

Where to point it

Everything above describes a shift. This part is a recommendation.

The capability is agnostic in principle and very much not neutral in effect. Where it gets aimed decides whether it was worth having.

Aimed at systems, it is the best available use of the tool. Legal filings. Tax structures. Corporate chains. Statutory language and who drafted it. Obligations that dissolved into bankrupt shells while the value walked out ahead of the filing. These are the places where complexity and cost — not secrecy — did the concealing. Nothing was hidden. It was too expensive to follow, and the expense worked as a wall with a door on only one side. Removing the expense isn't an attack on anyone. It makes a public record actually public, which is the only thing it was ever claimed to be.

That covers an enormous amount of ground: how a statute got written and who gained from it, where an obligation went when the company folded, what a chain of title actually says, which few names keep reappearing under new entities. All documented. All legal to read. None of it readable, until now, by anyone without a budget.

Aimed at your neighbor, it is corrosive, and I would advise against it. The person down the street holds no public trust, exercises no regulatory authority, and drafted no statute. There is nothing there to hold accountable. What gets produced is a file on a private individual who has no forum to answer in and no way to make it expire. The harm is immediate, permanent, and about nothing.

It also poisons the ground for everything else. The fastest route to public records being sealed is a visible wave of ordinary people hurt by strangers with a search tool — and the restrictions written in response to that will not be drawn narrowly. The neighbor-mapping does not just cause its own damage. It buys the closure of the window for the work that actually mattered.

The distinction is not subtle. Public power and public money leave public records deliberately, and following them is the purpose those records serve. A private life leaves no such trail by design, and assembling one anyway — because it has become possible — is a different act wearing the same tools.

What it's for

Deeper research is now available to individuals than has ever been available to individuals. Not privileged information — the same public record that has always been there, finally cheap enough to read all the way through.

Pointed at legal filings, tax structures, and the deliberately complicated machinery of ownership and obligation, it can unobscure a great deal of what complexity and cost have kept invisible. That is worth doing, and the window in which to do it is open now.

A description of a structural shift, with a recommendation about where to aim it. Not a forecast and not legal advice.

End of working note.

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